



**IMMACULATE
VOICE
OF THE
INFECTED STAR**

MATT PAYNE

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I

Humans swarmed the yard,
like ants respecting police tape.
They formed a shell protecting
a yolk of tragedy.

Maude LaFleur wore leather gloves
and crossed the road and
skirted the writhing throng
into the neighboring yard
and climbed over the wooden fence,
concealed by green leaves of summer.

The sliding back door was open.
Maude went inside and stole
loose change, two pens,
gray security card, USB drives
from a dish she emptied into her purse.

The sound of police talk,
low and murmuring
from a nearby room.

The fridge a great white frame
for a single photo
of a man and a boy.
She took a photo of the photo
with her phone.

Maude dared peek around the corner
and witnessed a woman naked
dead in the living room,
intestines and flesh-strips
splashed across white carpet,
studied by detectives.

The face still expressed the terror
of her final moments.

Maude took a picture
and vomited into the empty dish
and put the dish in the fridge
and drank some milk.

She had seen the woman's spine
and her rib cage
and bite marks.
Her tits had been eaten off.

Maude imagined having
her own tits devoured,
and was only slightly aroused
while marching out of the kitchen
as if she belonged there.
Nodding at a cop who nodded back,
Maude went upstairs.

In a baby's room a crucifix
over an empty crib.

On a table by the window
a blue orb translucent,
held by three metal fingers,
and a leatherbound book:
Secret Realities,
esoteric encyclopedia
whose musty pages contained
this bookmarked entry:

Nowhere Monks:
hungry thralls to the stars
who may fold themselves
into our reality.

Three picture panels:
One blank;
Two, a ghastly face smiling peeks
around from nowhere;
Three, a robed monk floats
among the stars.

Other entries Maude tried to read,
Speaking Stars and *Babayaga*,
but she could not read them,
because the blue orb
in her peripheral vision
the blue translucent orb
gave her a headache.

The blue orb reflected the room
but she was not in the reflection,
like a vampire.

Maude looked out the window
for relief from the orb's headache
and in the sky a robe
appeared flapping like laundry
rippled by a breeze that
didn't move the trees.

The rippling robe revealed
a man's face of rugged

jaundiced leather and deep eyes

burning dull red.

He floated in the sky and gazed at her,

his robes flowing around him

like a corona.

2

Enter Maude into

downtown office space empty

wondering how Garth paid the rent.

Dank basement and cluttered,

in a dirty brick building.

Light from small high windows

captured gross dust dancing.

Cramped with desks,

outdated desktop computers,

papers spilling onto

unclean linoleum tiles.

She wrote an article,
sensationalist drivel
about that poor woman:
*Hannah Gibson Devoured
by Own Demonic Offspring.*

The Counterblast would enjoy
many clicks from the bloody
photo of Hannah Gibson's corpse.

Maude forgave herself
because it was an evil world.
She sent the story to Garth,
her boss who worked remotely
just like her co-workers.

She bought an e-book copy
of *Secret Realities*.

Babayaga:
This witch kidnaps girls

and mothers for her soups.

*But wise girls she opens
their latent feminine powers.*

One picture, a map
inside a crystal ball.

Speaking Stars:

*Their beams of light are alive
with the voice of the cryptogod.*

The entry for *Nowhere Monks* said
see Glitch Monks.

A modernized name
in this newer edition.

The Glitch Monk's picture she compared
to that she had taken
of the anomalous monk floating
beyond the baby's window.
Their faces matched
and looked at her together.

A chill across her skin.

Outside it was cloudy.

Maude searched news archives
revealing more death.

Fire had consumed Hannah

Gibson's husband Alex

and their four-year-old son.

Foul play suspected.

Alex Gibson's archived website
divulged his final employer:

Nebula-Cipher Crypto Solutions.

Maude rode a dirty bus

to their registered address.

A sparkling glass cube,

opaque reflective blue,

Nebula-Cipher Crypto Solutions,

reflecting the clouds,

next to a pizza place.

Nobody answered the buzzer.
So Maude climbed a dumpster out back,
slipped through the DeLorean gap
of an open window and fell
onto a sink
and onto the bathroom floor.

The hall flickering
buzzing dejected
beige doors silent
her footsteps echoes like human voices.

The gray security card
that Maude had stolen
from Hannah Gibson's dish
granted passage to room 306.

Inside a metallic tang
and dry grossness
made her sneeze.

Aisles of electronic equipment,
a server farm whose blinking lights
offered the only illumination
in a patternless pattern
screaming at her in the dark.

The noise was deafening.
Grinding whirring clicking
humming invading her skull.
Maude took pictures with her phone
and video to capture the feeling.

Dead composers live again
when their music enters the living.
Maude walked through the servers
trying to resurrect Alex Gibson,
until she reached a desk
with a laptop whose screen said
Block 43, 199, 999 Processing...
99.99%

She beheld the message change
upon its dull green background,
Block 43, 199, 999 Finished.
Start Next Block?

The clicking and grinding
of the computers ceased
leaving only the dull whoosh
of the fans
which themselves soon slowed unto silence.

Her ears rang in a quietude
which quickened her heart.
In a panic pressed YES,
the cacophony resumed,
comforting now.

She opened the emails,
saw notifications sent of
blocks compiled and
huge strings of random characters.

The inbox contained
a single email
unread.

Your hunches are like mine.

*We send all the data
and receive only money.*

What are we decoding?

These emails are unsafe.

We should meet.

Maude pressed REPLY:

Agreed. Where and when?

Maude pressed SEND.

Maude heard a voice
obscured by oppressive noise.

Nowhere to hide,
she stayed silent and
tried to discern the words but
they were gone.

The workstation was a library
of books on math, codes,
cryptography, astronomy.
Graph paper stacks
plotted coordinates
x, y, z,
and long numbers at
pencil-marked points.

A book titled *Star Map*
one bookmarked entry
scrawled over in pen,
Speaking Star.

The book and the graph paper
went into her purse.

And the voice spoke again,
too loud to ignore so
she focused on it and
it was soothing and sinister.

Maude crept toward the source of the voice,
but it was all around.

Then she lost it again,
replaced by awful computer clicking.
Infuriating mind-itch.

The voice returned
and Maude realized
the computer sounds were the voice,
an audio illusion
a sonic synthesis
or schizophrenia.

She stood among the blinking aisles
like stars speaking in code and
Maude learned the trick:
not to separate voice from clicks,
but clicks from whirring fans.

An alien sermon
built from blended clicks

Masculine voice in secret language.
One long word with no pause for breath.
The joy of it.

Arm gwyn shiv
bir dng lawdid
shoyalda baoth.

The voice became all.
Could a voice have no speaker?
An experience for nobody?

The laptop dinged,
the voice disappeared,
replaced by new email
with time and place to meet and
description of the man
black ball cap and ponytail.

She wrote it all down,
then sought the voice in the noise

but it eluded her
so she recorded the noise
on her phone.

3

In a coffee shop with wooden chairs
Maude studied the patrons
with paranoid attention
eating muffin after muffin.

Anybody could be him
if his description was a lie.
Black hat and ponytail
yet to arrive.

Night darkness through the window.
Quiet and no music.
Murmuring patrons
and softly turning pages.

The door chimes jingled,
a tall man entered
in the foretold attire.
He ordered some tea,
sat at a wooden table,
and read the Old Testament.

She would not speak.
Would not expose herself.
But waiting till closing time,
bought two more muffins,
and followed him out.
He might not suspect a woman.

Warm rain on the concrete,
and he disappeared
in the darkness of an underpass.

Into darkness she followed,
and he spoke to her from the dark,
Why did you follow me?
and she could not see him.

Fear made her silent.
Maude considered flight.
She had been exposed.

But she did not flee.
She was trapped by her own
curiosity.

To the darkness she spoke.
I'm Maude LaFleur,
a reporter for The Counterblast.
Alex Gibson and his wife
are dead and I heard a voice
in his server farm.
I used his emails and
pretended to be him.

From shadows he emerged,
handsome in the dark,
with beautiful eyes.
Dark clothes and ponytail.

He asked her,
What did it tell you?
What did the voice tell you?

She admitted she could not
understand the words.

He gazed at Maude
like he was mesmerized
and this mesmerized Maude.

The voice is alive,
he told her.
I've been studying it.
My name is Mattias.
How did Alex die?

Maude told him of the fire
and Hannah gruesome butchered.
She asked him
what the server farms were for.

Mattias answered,
*I didn't know Alex's name
until you told me.
But he explained that his wife
grew pregnant too fast
after she heard the voice.
And the voices compelled him
and told him to do things
and that made me jealous.*

Maude said,
*Okay but what
are the server farms for?*

Mattias answered,
*We are a digital assembly line,
compartmentalized and anonymous.
We did now know each other
or our employer.
Contact was forbidden.*

*Alex was a solver,
decrypting blocks of data.
I am a compiler,
fusing solved data,
with special algorithms,
transmitting it up the line.*

*We found each other when
Alex disassembled the software
that transmits his solved blocks,
and he patched it to send
encoded messages in metadata.
I also disassembled
to study incoming data
and found his secret message
including email address.*

Maude marveled
at these conspiracies
of curiosity.

Maude asked Mattias,

What kind of data?

What is it for?

Mattias whispered,

We do not know.

Alex tried to learn

where his encrypted data came from.

But I seek to discern

the source of the decryption keys.

Mattias' face distorted

in waves of pain and wonder.

The data is alive,

becomes the voice in the servers.

Alex believed

that it came from special stars

that have been programmed

to transmit living data.

But why why why

must we decrypt it?

Maude's skin tingled
with fear and joy.
This man was insane.
She asked Mattias,
Do you believe
that it comes from the stars?

Mattias pulled out
his Old Testament and answered,
Isaac Newton claimed
the Old Testament contained
encrypted data,
and he sought the decryption key.
I believe my employer
is an alchemist
unlocking an angel.

Maude felt like throwing up.
But the wave passed and she asked,
How can it produce that voice?

Mattias told her,
Hard disk drives
out of date and slow
but noisy clicks combine
in algorithmic life
to mimic human speech.

Maude's final question,
Then who killed Hannah?
And why?

Mattias' final answer,
Perhaps she learned too much.
And we should not follow her.

But Maude replied,
Perhaps she learned too little,
and we should keep in touch.

4

Back in Hannah's house,
in the nursery having broken
a window in the basement and cut
herself on the glass,
Maude beheld the blue stone.

Glowing on three-pronged pedestal,
this orb which once had caused
her head to ache
was now a joy to behold.

Translucent blue orb
reflecting the room
with Maude's image absent
a warmth in her womb.

She picked up the orb
in two hands and turned
til the image within
its perspective matched hers.

The image in the orb suddenly
moved forward through the door
so she followed down the stairs
keeping orb-image matched
with her own perspective,
and when it strayed from overlap
the headache did come back.

But matching her view
with the orb's blue gloom
put warmth in her womb.

She followed the ghostly image
out into the night
to the outskirts of town
through a path behind a parking lot

to the train tracks
and their gauntlet of soft rustling leaves
beneath the stars' sparkling song.

Past factories aglow
whose night-shift workers
smoking cigarettes and watching
this woman and her luminescent
blue orb.

At sunrise the orb-image strayed
away from the tracks down into the trees,
and she followed,
and she tripped,
dropping the orb which bounced
off a rock and she tumbled
and fell through fern and thorn,
tearing blouse and scratching skin.

Maude landed not on the ground,
but suspended by foliage,

supported by bushes,
entangled by vegetation
in the fledgling light.

With a knife from her purse
Maude hacked at the vines,
and they came alive and
grabbed at her like tentacles.
So she burned them with her lighter
and the vines relented
and she stood on the ground
before a wall of writhing vegetation.

Maude's heart pounded at the sight.
Excited by claustrophobia
and the aggression
and the attention
of the animal movements
of these plants.

She noticed a patch of blue

embedded in the living wall.

Maude reached out and touched
an ass in blue jeans
and she felt its quivering warmth
and she heard somebody moan.

She asked the ass,

Do you need help?

But nobody answered.

She pulled the vines apart
and they grabbed at her wrists,
so she backed away
and they swallowed the ass.

A patch of skin bulged
through shrubs and blossoms,
a pregnant belly.

Elsewhere knees and elbows jutted
but mostly pregnant bellies.
Milk leaked from breasts

and she wanted to drink it
like drinking from a Christmas tree
of fertility.

It was a wall of women,
and the orb had been a lure
leading her here.
But they were all pregnant
and she was not.

Maude looked at her belly.
She was getting fat.
Or maybe just bloated
from all those muffins.
But she had always been thin
and it had been a year
since she last got laid.

A pretty face appeared
from the foliage and asked,
Are you the abortionist?

Maude saw a dark leather purse
and she grabbed it desperate
for the information it may hold.

A voice cried out,
That's my purse you bitch!
But Maude broke the strap
and liberated the bag.

Branches and roots spread apart,
an oval-shaped opening
writhing and pulsing,
a frightening dark canal.
But floating in the ceiling
she saw the blue orb
glowing in the gloom,
and a warmth in her womb.

Maude sobbed.
She didn't know why
she wanted so badly
to go inside.

Beyond the orb a shadow,
a creature among the shadows
with living dancing hair.

It whispered harsh rasp,
*Everything that belongs to you
is inside here.*

Come in or go away.

Maude backed away.

The tunnel closed.

The bellies and limbs were sucked
back into the tangled mess.

She climbed up to the tracks
bleeding where she had been scratched
and built an inukshuk of stone
and took a picture with her phone.

She had lost the orb,
but at least she'd stolen a purse.

5

Back to the office without sleep.
It seemed brighter now
and filled with men.

Warwick fat and gray,
boss Garth fat and ginger,
Dylan lean and twitchy
and neatly combed hair.
All chattering in the filthy
office like vermin.

Oh ho she arrives!

They were happy to see her
because of the horrible
photo of Hannah Gibson.
Many clicks they'd enjoyed.
Many new subscriptions.

And Maude was happy
to see her men because
she had something to show them,
but first she vomited
into the wire wastebasket
and her greenish puke oozed
through the wire mesh
and onto the floor.

She cleaned it up while they laughed
and called it morning sickness and
mentioned her fattening belly.

Garth went to get coffee.
Maude plugged her phone into
cheap computer speakers
and played the recording
from Alex Gibson's office.

She asked Dylan and Warwick,
What do you hear?

Do you hear the voice?

I hear a bunch of clicks,

Dylan answered.

The voice is made of the clicks,

Maude explained.

Like a big picture

made of smaller pictures.

Warwick asked.

Are you on drugs?

She pressed STOP.

Nevermind.

Warwick said,

Wait,

Turn it back on.

She did as he asked,
and watched his expression

transform to dismay,
and she knew he heard the voice.

He demanded to know,
What the fuck is this?
This isn't human.

Her skin was crawling.
Maude stopped the recording.
Dylan asked,
Can you make me a copy?

She uploaded the file
onto their shared server and then
their landline phone rang
and Maude answered.

He called himself Father Naman,
and claimed to have been
Hannah Gibson's priest.
He had read Maude's article
and wanted to meet her.

6

A Gothic church of granite stone
weeping calthemite stains
and a sagging steeple reminding Maude
of the stink of rot.

The trees all dead and the grass
trampled to hardpan.
Barren fountain flowing with trash,
all protected by wrought-iron fence.

Maude ascended stone stairs and stood
beneath the arches of the entrance.
The latch lifted
and rusty hinges screeched
the red painted doors opened
revealing a man.

The black suit of a priest
complete with white collar
but all stitched together
from different black suits
sewn crooked and wrong,
a Frankensuit.

A lean man in his fifties
with olive-skinned face,
Maude saw herself reflected
in his sparkling eyes.

Maude LaFleur, I presume,
the priest offered his hand
in its black leather glove
which was cold.

And his hair was black
and his earrings sparkled.

His high melodic voice
with repetitive rhythms,

suspiciously gentle
and mesmerizing said,
I am Father Naman,
and this is my church,
as he led her inside.

You knew Hannah Gibson?
she asked of the priest
as she studied the insides
of his church.

He led her through pews
haphazardly arranged
and their varnish worn away.
Great stained-glass windows
depicted strange creatures
in low-poly graphics.

She was a troubled woman,
Naman answered in a voice
that drank tragedy.

*She wanted an exorcism
but I am no exorcist.*

He stopped at the stage
and turned around smiling.
Behind him the pipe-organ loomed
with crooked pipes like broken fingers,
or spider legs.

Above the organ a crucifix hung
also crooked where Jesus
snarled with sharp teeth,
his crown of thorns laced
with tentacles
and his loincloth failed to cover
another tentacle.

Can we speak in your office?
Maude asked the priest,
while eyeing a door ajar.
She was already recording.

Naman's smile widened.

I'm afraid it's too messy.

Let's sit in the pews.

He sat and crossed his hands
and his long fingers in their gloves
intertwined seemed to have no knuckles,
like tentacles.

Maude sat down beside him.

Who killed Hannah Gibson?

she bluntly asked the priest,
suspecting it was him.

Father Naman told Maude,

I hoped you could tell me,

or else I might help you

in your investigations.

I am a huge fan

of The Counterblast.

And that was the most
disturbing thing of all.

Next Maude inquired,
What kind of church is this?
Why did Hannah come to you?
while she tried not to look
at the tentacle-penis of the Lord.

Naman's eyes gazed beyond and he answered,
We believe that this world is a prison
where the creator god entangles
the light of our souls.
But Jesus is an emissary
from beyond that god's realm.
He's the key for decryption,
a freedom spell.

Hannah was convinced
that her baby was a demon.
She said she was pursued
by men walking backwards,
and she heard strange voices.
She said they could beam themselves

here on pure starlight.

Maude almost touched her own belly,
but stopped herself and asked,
Was there any truth to this?
Was she being pursued?

Naman giggled and said,
You're positively glowing.
Are you worried they might
rip your baby out next?

Maude choked and gulped.
What baby?
I'm not pregnant.
Do you think I should be worried?

Naman answered,
Most women can grow a baby.
But can you nurture a child?
Can you embrace the screaming monster

and love its ugliness?

Only then can you avoid

Hannah's fate.

I'm not pregnant,

Maude repeated,

but her voice was drowned out

by rumbling vibrations

rattling pews into new arrangements,

and the stones seemed to quake.

The sounds merged together

into a whale's song,

deep and mournful.

And carried on the song

Maude heard that old voice

synthesized from the rattlings.

Moz nodam kristum

Olan xona shig

Her vision blurred
and the voice absorbed her.
It spoke from everywhere
and vibrated her body.
Something suckled her breast
and whispered in her ear
Jesus is a lie.

There is only evil.

*If your baby was evil
would you show it compassion?*

And Maude whispered, *yes.*

Suddenly the voice stopped
and Maude sat alone on the pew
sweating and panting.

Where was the priest?
She saw him discussing
with a man in a robe by the wall.
The man walked backwards

with gliding swishing robe
into a door of pure blackness
and Naman followed the man
down unseen stairs.

Maude's breast was exposed
and smeared with cold black slime.
She put it back in her blouse
and noticed a necklace
with a stone of bright green
which faded to black in the center.
She pulled off the necklace
and put it in her purse.

Then she found Naman's office.
The door slightly ajar.
She was shaken and shivering
as she browsed through a collection
of VHS tapes on a shelf.
Each tape had a woman's name
in black marker on the label,

and one of the names
said *Hannah Gibson*.

Maude put the tape in her purse
along with two others
and fled the building.

7

Maude didn't own a VCR
so she bought one from a pawn shop
and took a shortcut through an alley.

From the corner of her eye
she saw fluttering robes near the roof
of the brick building on her left.
It was one of those monks
a glitch monk
a nowhere monk
and he flew backwards

and Maude's eyes followed him
which is how she spotted the man
walking behind her and holding a knife.

Black jeans and gray hoodie and
ball cap with the beak pulled down
he lunged at her and
Maude smashed his head with the VCR
and he stumbled moaning
against the brick wall.

The monk still floated in the sky.
His leathery skin was blue
his eyes were static.
The monk kept turning
but never completed the rotation,
just glitching back to the start
a broken loop of animation.

The thug rushed her again
but he stumbled drunk

from the blow to the head.
So Maude smashed him again
and he dropped the knife
and they wrestled for the knife.

The man growled at her
Your babies must die!
Your babies are monsters!
And Maude pushed the knife
into his throat.

His blood pulsed and spurted
and he gargled up blood
that splashed on his chin and cheek.

Maude scrambled away
splattered with blood
clutching the knife
then she went back
and took his wallet.

The glitch monk was closer now
still doing his broken dance and
another monk was crawling
down the wall like a mechanical spider.
He would crawl a few feet
then suddenly appear one foot behind.
And more monks were coming
moving shifting appearing.
They were closing in.

Maude backed away.
She tripped and fell and scraped
her hands on the pavement
crawling backwards and staring
terrified.
And they converged
on her attacker's corpse.

8

The VCR's shell was busted
but miraculously still worked
when she hooked it to her TV
inserted the Hannah Gibson tape
and sat on the floor to watch it.

The video was grainy.
Hannah Gibson sat on the floor
of her living room naked and pregnant.
Her hands were bound
behind her head with a spreader bar.
Her sobs muted by ball gag.

Father Naman and three robed figures
stood around her illuminated
by candlelight and framed by murk.

Naman chirped to the woman,

Time for your exorcism.

*Console yourself with the fact
that nothing could have saved you
not after hearing the voice.*

The abortionists were no solution.

*When a man hears the voice
he may choose to obey it
embrace the darkness
or else fire consumes his mind
and he consumes himself with fire.*

*When a woman hears the voice
she has no choice to make
fire only feeds her offspring.*

*The babies will be born
and they will eat her.*

There is no escape.

Naman began to sing
the song from the servers
though his voice lacked the range

and depth of what she'd heard before.

The three robed men repeatedly
stabbed Hannah's pregnant belly
as she wailed
until it became
a perforated wasteland of flesh.

They grabbed at the flesh
and ripped her open and
reached into the womb
and pulled out three babies,
dangled them by their ankles
or was it their tails?

Maude leaned in to squint.
Were they human babies?
Or were they lizards or worms?
The babies wriggled and transformed.
Cute cheeks and blue eyes became
a winged snake

they shimmered and contorted
became babies again
ever changing.

Hannah was alive
screaming muffled by ball gag
when the men began to consume her
buried their faces in her guts
and ripped her flesh with their teeth.
The babies crawled over her
feasting on her shaking body
eating her tits.

Naman's song dropped an octave
and the three men stood from their feast.
The newborns cried and giggled,
hissed and clicked.
The men opened their bloody mouths
and bit into soft infant flesh.
The giggling stopped and
the hissing increased

and shrieking.

Bite after bite they consumed

the babies alive

while Hannah gasping

and bleeding watched.

Bones tentacles faces and brains

all were consumed.

Maude ran to the bathroom and vomited

then came back and watched

the other videos

which followed the same formula

with different female leads.

She didn't sleep that night

just stayed up watching the videos

compulsively.

She researched the women online

found news stories for each name.

One missing and the other found dead

mutilated like Hannah.

Maude's belly grew by the hour
and sooner or later
her babies would eat her.
Her frazzled mind searched
for answers and found none.

What had Naman meant
when he had told Hannah
that the abortionists would not save her?
He might have been lying.
Who were the abortionists?
Maybe Maude could find them.

She opened her digital copy
of *Secret Realities* and found
nothing about abortions.
She lingered on the entry
about the *Babayaga*,
and its picture of a crystal ball
with the map inside.

She remembered the women
trapped in the trees
and the whispering shadow
in the cave of leaves
and she took out the purse
from the woman she'd thieved.

Crumbled lipstick
thirty dollars in cash
and a hand-written note that said
Don't trust Naman!
Go to Jeff's House!
The missing apostrophe upset Maude
but at least there were directions
to *Jeff's House*.

9

The directions to *Jeffs House* said
Farhaven Settlement
cemetery behind the church
through the fence gate
more graveyards and forest
Jeffs House.

And so she went to Farhaven Settlement
which was a historical recreation
of an early colonial town.
She had to wear sweatpants now
to accommodate her new girth.
While sitting on the bus
she had felt a baby kick.

Maude bought a ticket at the booth
and returned to the past

where men in tunics followed her
down the muddy dirt road
through churn of butter and clang
of blacksmith's hammer between
thatch-roofed abodes
past the white wooden church
at the far end of town.

The cemetery behind was unkempt.
Each gravestone loomed crooked
over a sunken grave.
The back gate wrought iron
and covered in vines
and too tall and spiky
for a pregnant woman to climb.

She found a fallen corner
of a crumbled gravestone and
the men still followed her so
she smashed the lock frantically.

The rusty lock broke apart
and she struggled against the vines
to pull the gate open.

She wedged herself through but
a man grabbed her blouse
so she smashed his elbow
with the gravestone shard
and he fell back crying.

More graves lay beyond the gate.
Maude walked among the dead
beneath a canopy of trees.
Soon the ancient gravestones became
anonymous white wooden crosses.

A woman knelt at a wooden cross
eyes shut and mumbling a prayer.
A pretty redhead with short dreadlocks
and an earth-colored cloak.
A tear trickled down her cheek.

I'm looking for Jeff's House

Maude told the woman.

The sad woman took Maude's hand
and led her into a great grassy field
with a cluster of tents and log huts
in the center of the field.

Smoke rising from a great fire.

The white crosses ceased
at the field's perimeter.

Maude put her hand in her purse
and clutched the bloody knife
from yesterday's attacker.

Women churning butter and
sewing and gardening
watched Maude and her guide pass
through a leather flap in a door
into a log hut where
Maude was surrounded
by menacing men wearing

hemp pants and tunics.

Maude pulled her guide close and
pressed the knife to her neck.

I'm looking for Jeff's House!

I want an abortion!

Somebody said

It's her, the reporter,

and that's Jason's knife,

and that's Jason's blood.

Maude quivered with rage.

You sent that man to kill me?

Why?

Let me explain

said a man on the floor

languid smile, long hair, strong jaw.

I am Jeff's House,

and I serve all these women.

Everybody relax.

She's looking for help.

You don't look like a house,

Maude snapped at the man.

I am two Jeffs

because my twin brother

devoured me in the womb

but I took over his mind

and our last name is House.

The babies in your belly

are a demonic invasion

to be be killed or contained

and it's easier to kill them

because to contain them

you must live with us forever

and we do not trust you.

Maude did not want to live here
she did not like the vibes.

I want an abortion.

I want to kill my babies.

Jeffs House shook his head.

An abortion would kill you

as would giving birth

but we know a sonic spell

to trap them unborn

but it also traps you here

like all of these women.

Maude whispered

into the redhead's ear,

is it true?

And the woman said,

they freed me from my babies

but if I leave I die

and that's why you found me

weeping at my friend's grave.

Jeffs House continued,
*We know you spoke with Naman
just like Hannah Gibson
and we cannot allow his monks
to feed upon your children.
But if you would stay
we could protect the world
from your awful babies.*

Now Maude was weeping
because she didn't want to stay
and she didn't want to die
and the babies were kicking and
writhing in her belly.

*Please help me.
Please do the sonic spell.
Take away my babies.*

Men took her arms
and Maude relinquished the knife
and collapsed into the arms
of the woman she had threatened.

The woman held Maude and said,
My name is Rebecca,
and I understand
and I forgive you
and we accept you.

Jeffs House spoke
and Maude saw a rope
running out of his pant leg
like a worm or umbilical cord
disappearing under the rug.
We will do the sonic spell
and then you will be trapped here
but we men are here to serve you.

Sourness broke through Maude's fear
and she snarled at Jeffs House,
How convenient for you
to trap all these women
so you can always fuck them.

The men all shared a grinning look
and a sparkle in their eye.
Of course we do make love
but that love serves the women
as it serves the men
and we will never force you
but you will get lonely.

Maude wept again
ashamed of her outburst
but still skeptical
and overwhelmed.

Jeffs House continued,
We always experiment

*with new spells to free our women
but so far nothing has worked.*

*Today we're trying something new,
an object we discovered,
an object called Bethikabox
which exists backwards in time
and it may allow a woman
to finally leave this place.*

*Rebecca has volunteered
to carry Bethikabox
and see if it allows her
to exit through the cemetery gate.*

*You will accompany her
and be with her when she escapes
or when she dies.*

*Then you will be one of us
and we will do the sonic spell.*

A gray-bearded man produced a black cube
cradling it by adjacent sides
and not touching the corners.
He gave it to Rebecca saying,
*The corners are infinitely sharp
and the sides are infinitely black.*

Maude walked beside her out the door
and through the village to the field
all the women watching them.
Rebecca muttered prayers
and held the cube like a diamond
as they entered into the trees
passing through the wooden crosses
of all the women
who had tried to leave.

If they made it to the fence
then Rebecca would be free
and they could see the fence now.
Nearer and nearer they came

until Rebecca stepped beyond
the final wooden cross.

Just before the gate she turned
and said Maude's name in trembling voice
watery eyes and shaking hands
the black cube crumbled to dust
that sifted through Rebecca's fingers
and the young woman fell to her knees,
face forward in the brambles she fell.

Maude rushed forward
and turned the girl over and
checked for a pulse
and found none.

Three men had been following
with shovels and a white wooden cross
and they started digging.

This is the furthest anybody's gone.

Our spell is improving.

Maude saw this as a threat
to keep sex slaves in line.
She thought about fleeing
and saw children on the other side
of the gate holding knives
their parents looming over them
dark eyes and serious
dressed in colonial attire
while inside Maude's guts
demon babies danced.

She marched back to Jeffs House
as the sun sank from the sky.

IO

They held a funeral in the dark
for Rebecca.
Women in robes
sporadic candlelight

strange mournful chanting.

When the stars came out
men approached Maude
and said to take off her clothes
and put her purse aside.
They threw her clothes in the fire
and they found Naman's necklace
in her purse
and threw it in the fire and
lay her down on a stone altar
beside a wooden hut.

The women dropped their robes
and Maude was surrounded
by naked women
and naked men in the firelight
pubic hair on exposed bodies
of every shape and size.

The men took ropes
hanging from the walls of the hut
and pulled down the walls of the hut
revealing a giant slug within.

The slug's leathery skin convulsed
in weird wriggling waves
creating interference patterns.

A giant spike impaled the slug
and pinned it to the ground.
The slug thrashed against the spike
producing a steady flow of ooze
pulsing from the spike-wound.
Gore spilled slowly down its body
but the monster's translucent skin
was full of mouths that opened
and licked up the clumpy goo
re-consuming its own fluids.

The slug was trying to turn
turn over like the glitch-monks
but it was nailed in place.

Maude saw silhouettes of shapes
within the slug's translucent body.

She saw babies.

The thing was packed with little
human babies.

She saw their pudgy arms and legs
and their bald heads
asleep with their eyes closed
and sucking their thumbs.

Forever unborn
this giant sack of infants
was somehow alive.

No, she was mistaken,
the babies were not human.
She saw tails and lizard skin
among this awful nursery.

Yes these were demon babies
as she'd seen in Hannah's video
like those growing in her womb.

Her womb was restless
her babies were kicking
her muscles spasmed uncontrollably.
Did her children know
what she was about to do?

Men placed smooth stones on her body
as she lay back on the altar
and looked up at the stars
which sparkled mocking at her weakness.

Two more men she'd never seen
floated in the sky above her
lean and nude and drawn with tattoos
bald with leathery old skin.
Umbilical cords connected them
to the impaled and writhing slug

as the women chanted guttural chorus.

Maude asked the men attending her,

Who are those men

those floating men

what are their gestures

what are they chanting?

The men attending her answered,

Those two men are our priests

the children of a witch

we fed to the slug

a long time ago.

Maude tried to breathe normal

and found herself sweating and

panting.

She imagined the glitch monks

ever turning and wondered

why they never completed their turn.

She remembered the voice in the church
how she'd promised to protect
her evil babies.

She recalled where the orb had led her
and the creature in the shadows who said
Everything that belongs to you,
is inside here.

Come in or go away.

How Maude had gone away.
And the stars sparkled and mocked her.
And her babies danced in her womb.

Maude wondered what they could become
what her babies could become
if she allowed them to consume her.

The priests levitated above her chanting,
one placing a stone on her head
and the other placing a smaller stone
between her legs

trying to push it inside her
and the stone was warm.

She grabbed his umbilical cord
and tore it from his body and
he stopped chanting as thick black goo
bubbled in chunky pulses
out of his belly button
and he floated away.

The other priest reached for his brother
so Maude tore out his cord too
and they floated away hand-in-hand
with ghastly looks on their faces
while people scrambled with ropes
and Maude grabbed her purse
and ran naked for the forest.

Three of the women chased her
shrieking like demons themselves
shrieking about her demon babies.

But Maude was pregnant and slow
and the women soon caught her
tackled her to the ground
dragging her by the feet
her bare ass across the grass
but Maude took the knife from her purse
and slashed and stabbed at her captors
and they wrestled for her knife.

Jeffs' magic keeps you here,
Maude rasped at the conniving bitches,
and she straddled a woman and
plunged the knife in her throat and
drank the gushing blood
and kissed the woman's dying lips.

While the other women cried at the blood
Maude ran laughing into the trees.

II

Thrashing through forest darkness
naked except for her purse
hysterical laughter from bloody mouth
bleeding from scratches
laughing and weeping.

To the train tracks she wandered
and just as dawn arrived
she found her little inukshuk and
climbed down the embankment.

The wall of women waited
and the greenery opened up
revealing the blue orb glowing
pulsing in the writhing ceiling.
She stepped into the cave of vines
and they swallowed her up.

The tunnel's floor was warm and moist
smelling like mushrooms and cinnamon.

The orb moved away
luring her deeper
as the walls closed in.

The squeezing walls felt like flesh
lubricating her with their mucus
she felt round bellies
she saw women's faces
and she softly kissed their lips.
Then she reached the orb and held it
and caressed it and wondered
if its warmth was radioactive.

She pushed into a wide cavern
whose dim wriggling walls dripped
with a dark reddish goo.
More lady-parts were embedded
in those walls like decorations.
Legs and breasts and pregnant bellies

dimly illuminated by luminescent flowers.

Something moved in the darkness
like a disembodied floating beard
or a tumbleweed flying past her.
It disappeared and reappeared
as if darkness were a pool
for diving in and out.

The flying beard circled closer.
Revealing a haggard smiling face
with warts on its nose
and a straggly mane of unkempt hair
and a tattered comet's tail
of ragged clothes
and spindly arms and legs.

Who sent you to join my wall?
The flying crone asked Maude
in a tone of mocking pity.

Maude yelled at the crone,
Nobody sent me!
I will not join your wall!
I want to have my babies
but I don't want them to eat me!

The crone circled round and round
laughing and cackling and said,
So you're afraid of being eaten?
You want safe little babies?
Fear has no place in here!
So you will join my wall
we will make your babies safe
I will take away your fear!

Vines wrapped around Maude's ankles
around her wrists and thighs
and pulled her against the wall.
The blue orb floated beyond her reach
up into the ceiling.

Maude struggled against the vines
but they were too strong
and their mucus warmed her skin
with intoxicating pleasure.

Maude cried,
No! Not this!
I will not join your wall!
Help me make my babies strong!
I'll do whatever it takes!

The flying crone cackled again,
Then why are you talking?
You must sing me a song!

Maude tried to think of a song
but fear and rage crowded her thoughts
as the vines pulled her deeper
so instead she screamed.

Maude began to cry
women's hands grabbed her hair
mucus covered her face
soothing pleasure enveloped her body
quickenning her anger
she screamed,
this isn't fair!

But someone whispered in her ear,
*We know you don't belong here
and we've heard the witch's song
the Babayaga wants to hear
so we will play your body
as our instrument
we'll teach you the song as you scream
with rage and pleasure.*

A dozen hands touched her body
stroked and squeezed her everywhere
and she screamed in rage
the people she'd killed

the monsters in her belly.
She screamed different notes
when a finger pushed here
or a palm stroked there
making Maude their instrument
teaching Maude a song.

The vines stopped pulling her in
and started pushing her out and
lifting her up.

The hands could no longer reach her
they let her go
but Maude kept singing the song
a thousand notes
a wondrous song of atonal beauty
expressing feelings she'd never had
ancient feelings buried inside her
now awoken.

Maude sang her own pleasure
on the rising bed of vines
as the wallflowers glowed like stars
and the blue orb floated above her
and it split open spilling
its glowing liquid onto her chest
she felt its cool tingle
absorb into her skin.

Yesss oh yesss!
the Babayaga witch cooed
and buried her haggard face
into the spilled substance
pouring over Maude's body.

Maude's eyes rolled back in her head
the vines pushed her through the ceiling
her body convulsed in orgasm
her song hit a bottomless tone.

The Babayaga whispered,

*Sing this song for Father Naman
and force him to prepare your body
with the black milk to sustain
the birth of your children.*

Maude still moaned with pleasure
when light attacked her eyes
and she saw she was in an alley
laying on a pile of garbage
clutching her slime-covered purse.

She stood up naked and pregnant
and covered in slime and quivering
with pleasure and she saw
three teenage boys smoking
and staring at her.

She emptied a stinking garbage bag
and tore three holes for arms and head
and wore the garbage bag like a dress and
walked to her apartment.

I2

Maude's phone bleated like a lamb
She woke up on her couch covered
in the crust of yesterday's slime.
She answered the phone
and heard her boss Garth
barking like a dog.

*Maude! Did you see the news?
Warwick's apartment building
is burned to the ground!
Thirteen people died!
And Dylan's not answering his phone.*

Maude stared at her curtain
dancing lightly in the breeze
and it reminded her
of the glitch monks.

She told Garth,
*It was the voice in the servers
that I played for them.
Warwick burned himself alive
but Dylan probably joined them.
Whatever you do
don't listen to that recording.*

Garth incredulous growled,
*The fuck are you talking about?
I listened to that this morning.
It's just some stupid voice.
I never burned anything down.
Come into the office.*

Maude squeezed shut her eyes
and ended the call
and waddled into the shower
with her babies wriggling inside her.

After she was clean and dried

Maude put on a loose-fitting dress
and called Mattias
Alex's former colleague.
He answered after one ring
and immediately told her
in a voice desperate and confused
that he couldn't stop thinking about
burning down his house.

Don't burn down your house.
Mattias I need your help.
I'm going to visit a priest
who can help me birth my babies
and maybe he can help you
with how you want to burn things.

She told him her adventures
and he took it rather well
and he agreed to meet her
at Father Naman's church.
So she packed some knives and left.

13

Mattias waited for her at the gates
with a baseball bat in one hand
flicking a lighter in the other
adorned in black beneath the gray sky.
His eyes were suspicious
and darting around
and soot stained his face.

They climbed the stone stairs
to the crooked stone church
and knocked on the door
and Father Naman answered smiling
in his crooked suit.

You've returned to the flock.

And you brought a friend.

How delightful.

Maude looked in his eyes

and his eyes were like worms
and she told the hideous priest,
*I need you to prepare my body
with the black milk to sustain
the birth of my children,
but I watched your video tapes
of what you did to Hannah
and you won't do that to me,
Mattias is my backup.*

Naman crossed his heart and said,
I would never dream of it!
*My monks and I don't want to suffer
the wrath of the great Mattias!*

Inside the church beneath the gaze
of Jesus with his tentacle crown,
Naman led them through a side door
down a stairway into pure darkness.

No walls or rails to hold
just blackness all around
stairs terminating far below
beneath a cone of light illuminating
an island of cobblestone floor.
And in the center an altar.

To this altar Naman led them,
a stone slab with manacles on chains,
and he told her to take off her clothes
and lay on the altar.

Cold wind blew from the darkness
softly ruffling Maude's hair
as she gazed at the chains
and shivered because she knew
that Naman would lie
and he would kill her and
eat her babies,
so she told the priest,
I will take off my clothes

*but I will not wear the chains,
and I need you to tell me
how this ritual will work.*

Naman strolled around the altar
like a used car salesman and said,
*You will lay down
and I will sing
a song to bring forth your children
and a creature will come from the dark
to turn your milk black
so your babies will drink your milk
instead of eating your flesh
and feasting on your screams.*

So Maude took off her dress
and removed her underwear
with shaking hands standing
naked and pregnant before these two men.

Her breasts had grown larger
a drop of white milk dripped
from a cold-hardened nipple.

And she said to Mattias,
if he tries anything
bash his fucking brains in.

Mattias looked at her seriously
and tapped the wooden baseball bat
against the cobblestone floor.

And the two men helped her climb
upon the altar and then
each man clamped a manacle
over one of her wrists.

Maude shouted,
What is this?
Why have you chained me?
Mattias what have you done?

Mattias pocketed his lighter and
smiled as his eyes groped her body.

*Maude I want to eat your babies,
and enjoy your body with violence.*

I heard the voice and I obeyed.

*I want show you what I have become,
what my mind has become.*

You are the vessel of my transformation.

*Your torture,
your dismantling,
will be a pure joy.*

And he sucked on her tit
and drank of her milk
while Father Naman laughed.

And from the darkness emerged
Garth and Dylan
her colleagues walking
and they grabbed her feet and
chained her ankles in manacles

and their hands explored her body

while she struggled and growled,

You traitors!

You weaklings!

Warwick chose the fire!

From the infinite blackness above

glitch monks floated down

turning but never turning

holding stone trays

stone trays on which they carried

sharp hooks and knives and saws.

Thank you for making us listen,

thank you for bringing us the voice,

Dylan said as he rubbed her thigh

and Mattias took a hook from a tray

and approached Maude's legs

which two traitorous men held open.

More monks appeared in the black sky
turning from nowhere
shimmering in their glitch dance
watching Mattias press the hook
gently between her legs
like a knife to a pie.

Maude's tension and rage
shook her teeth and her eyeballs
quivering with hate
yet excited with love
for a horror which was her equal
and she screamed and she whined
and her pitch wandered chaotically.
Maybe her mind was collapsing or
maybe it was a song.

Mattias ogled and drooled at the prospect
of fucking her with a sharp hook
but then he dropped the hook
the blade clattered on the floor

his face was distorted
like the flesh was being pulled
by invisible hands,
he rubbed his face like it was itchy,
with terror in his eyes,
What's happening to me?

Maude's song dropped an octave
and she sang in an insane key,
the flesh was torn from Mattias' face
and he fell screaming to his knees.

Mattias' clothes were torn off
and flew into the void
and he lay on the floor crying
pleading for mercy
bloody gibbering skeletal face.

Maude knew what she was doing
she sang the flesh from his body
she heard the skin tearing

peeling off in one great piece
which floated up like a charmed snake
and his muscles too were stripped
scattered into the infinite beyond.

Mattias' screaming stopped
but Maude's song had just begun.
Dylan rushed her with a ball-gag,
and Garth grabbed a knife from a tray
but something slithered
like snakes from the darkness.

Maude sang into the darkness
the listening darkness.

Tentacles from the void
wriggling a dance of slithers
black with green suckers
and wrapped around Dylan and Garth
lifting them into the air.

They ripped off Dylan's arms
tore him to pieces
and they squeezed Garth
until his bones crunched
and blood burst from his mouth.

More and more tentacles
they opened Maude's manacles
and wrapped around her body.
Cold clammy tentacles on her skin
but warm sucking suckers
strong muscles squeezing exploring
lifting her up.

Glitch monks were all around
like stars all watching her
and she was among them
a tentacle crawled up her leg
wrapped around her thigh
parted her labia and pushed
pushed itself inside her.

Maude gasped and moaned
her song another octave lower
sounds she'd never made before
tentacle deeper and deeper.

More of them found her body
with mouths on their tips
they sucked on her breasts
one entered her mouth
she explored it with her tongue
humming her song
as the other one fucked her.

Maude's orgasm came
convulsing in the air
and the tentacles pulsed
gushing black tar on her tits
in her womb
in her mouth.

The black tentacle cum tasted
like spicy molasses and cloves

and the darkness rumbled
a glorious moan.

The tentacles set her down
on the altar and when
the appendage exited her womb
it brought out three babies.

Three babies were turning
they turned over and were lizards
with extra eyes and teeth
then turned over and were human
ever turning and shimmering
and they were beautiful to Maude.

Two of them were boys
one blue and the other deep yellow
and the red one was a girl.
They crawled toward her breasts
and Maude saw her nipples
were oozing black milk.

She had been transformed.

Two of them drank her milk
while the third scrambled for access.

Father Naman loomed over her
with madness in his eyes and
clutched her arm and demanded,
What magic is this?
Where did you learn these spells?
I have to know!

She looked in his eyes,
and hummed a simple tune
and Father Naman flew
into the darkness.

Maude retrieved her dress
and gathered her babies in it.
Ascending the stairs she heard
the glitch monks singing.

I4

Since Dylan was dead
Maude thought it would be okay
to use his basement apartment
with its dedicated entrance
she could come and go unseen.

Finding a stash of drugs in a drawer
she ate some white powder
she didn't know what it was.

From Dylan's extensive record collection
Maude played a Lou Reed album
Metal Machine Music
and she danced naked in the living room
and her shimmering baby-things
danced and sang with her
little shrieks of alien joy.

Maude lay on the floor
and her babies took turns drinking
black milk from her breasts
but when her milk ran dry
they nibbled on her nipples
and she knew they needed more
than her body could provide.

So in the dead of night
Maude crept upstairs
to the house above the basement
where the landlady lived.
Maude sang a simple song
which unlatched the lock
and her babies followed her
to the landlady's bedroom.

Woman gently sleeping alone
middle aged and pretty
Maude sliced open her throat
the woman startled awake

gurgling blood and wide eyes
little monsters eating her.

The children grew and grew
eating the corpse all day
till only bones remained
kids now walking like toddlers.

Maude ate sandwiches in the kitchen
her black milk was replenished
she stole a dress from a drawer and
remembered the women
trapped by Jeffs.

From blankets and bath towels
Maude fashioned small robes and
her children thus adorned they
left in the morning
and walked to find Jeffs House.

They arrived in the evening and
Maude was surprised to find
Father Naman and his human monks
had claimed the little village.

Jeffs and his two tattooed priests
were crucified before the bonfire and
the great slug of babies ripped open
and Naman's monks eating them
and floating into the air
turning and becoming glitch-monks.

And the women all bound
to stakes in the ground
and Maude heard the voice
playing from stereos
roiling alien prayer command
making the women pregnant again
weeping and knowing their fates.

We must leave,

Maude hissed at her toddlers
but the triplets were gliding
through the grass dancing and singing
and turning and
they would not obey her
so Maude followed them
and she sang a song to shatter
the bones of the human monks who
fell wailing broken to the ground.

Glitch monks swooped down at her
in their staggered broken fashion
and her song would not hurt them
but only divert them
and Father Naman loomed over her
his hands on her throat
laughing and choking her
and she could not sing.

*Do you remember the necklace
I gave when you visited?
I followed it here to learn your song!
I did not learn your song
but I found food and women!
Transformations for my flock!*

Maude beat at his arms
but his fingers wrapped like snakes
lifting her and choking her
and she was helpless.

But she heard a song.
Her triplets circled around her
singing three part disharmony
atonal and dissonant
and beautiful and terrible and
Naman began to shake
and Naman screamed and
melted into snakes
that slithered away

and his clothes collapsed
and Maude fell gasping on the ground.

Maude threw Naman's clothes
into the fire,
and the human monks
with broken bones
she heaved into the fire,
and Jeffs and his priests
bleeding pleading on crucifixes
she set them on fire.

She turned off the stereos
and silenced the voice
and a blond woman said,
Now you can free us!

Maude smiled warmly and turned
to study the tools of torture
Naman's flock had left behind.
My babies can't eat your freedom.

Matt Payne lives in Ottawa.

His other books include:

Terranomicon,
Millenarianistic Chronodyke,
The Sick Book of Lies,
Probiotic Psychotic,
and
The Canadian Civil War.

Support his work by buying his books:

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